

Boeing B-52 Stratofortress



“Moving from a B-47 bomber to the ‘Buff’ was like progressing from a sportster to a stretched limousine.”

CAPTAIN GENE DEATRICK
1950s TEST PILOT

THE BOEING B-52, KNOWN TO AIRMEN as the “Buff,” has proved the most durable military aircraft in aviation history. First delivered to the US Strategic Air Command in June 1955, it is still used in frontline service today. The B-52 was designed specifically to drop nuclear bombs on the Soviet Union. But it turned out to be highly adaptable, able to change from high-altitude missions to low-level attack, to provide a platform for Cruise missiles, and to operate as a conventional bomber of awesome power in regional conflicts.

The B-52 was able to carry an impressive bombload in the bomb-bay or on pods under the wings. The “Big Belly” modification of the B-52D, for example, could carry 60,000lb (27,200kg) of bombs – almost five times the capacity of a World War II “heavy” such as the Lancaster.

The B-52 features a twin-deck forward fuselage. The pilot and copilot sit above, while the navigator and radar navigator crouch in the “black hole” below. The navigators’ ejection seats fire downward – a worrying fact on low-level missions. The electronic warfare officer (EWO) sits facing backward at the rear of the upper deck, with the gunner alongside, operating a tail gun by remote control. In early models of the B-52, the gunner sat out in a tail turret, buffeted and shaken a good deal. Coming in to the forward fuselage (in later models) made this job less isolated and uncomfortable.

Because it was originally thought that the B-52 would be attacked by missiles, it does not feature all-around guns (and partly accounts for the small crew of six). Missiles were instead dealt with by electronic countermeasures and chaff that blocked or distracted the missiles’ homing systems.

Weapons pylon attachment point



CRAMPED CADILLAC
Despite the fact that the B-52 has been dubbed “the Cadillac of the skies,” there is little room in the cockpit – or elsewhere. A person of average size is unable to stand upright anywhere in the craft, and only the pilots are able to see outside.

TALL TAIL

Although over the years the B-52 has progressed through a series of models and modifications, one of the constant features has been the tall vertical tail. However, on the B-52G (shown below), the tail is almost 8ft (2.5m) shorter than those found on previous models.

